strength from the RSS … Nobody gets along 100% with his wife. The BJP is closest to us with respect to other parties. Which other party is there for us to support in the country? Sonia Gandhi?'[61]

This is not to say that the BJP and RSS imports do not have discords. Power brings its own challenges. In Karnataka, before the assembly elections of 2018, B.L. Santhosh, a former RSS pracharak who had been appointed general secretary (organisation), and the party's chief ministerial candidate and former pracharak B.S. Yediyurappa were known to have political differences. They 'couldn't get along'. As a senior Karnataka BJP leader told me, 'Something happened and Yediyurappa said to the media, if Santhosh wants to control the party, he should run it. I will not do it. That shook up the party high command. Santhosh never speaks in public, but the enmity is not gone. It got resolved then because the High Command called and said "what is happening, it is an election year, sort it out". The local party was with Yediyurappa.'[62] Senior BJP MLC in the state, Lehar Singh, when asked about the RSS–BJP relationship, summed it up diplomatically: 'They have almost a good equation. It is not much of a problem and the political class is clever enough to have its way.'[63]

The current BJP–RSS relationship is very unlike what it used to be during the Vajpayee years, which were characterised by a permanent state of tension between the two. The RSS top brass would often go public with their critiques. In March 2000, for instance, RSS Chief K.S. Sudarshan called the PMO incompetent and lamented that the BJP had become 'Congressised'. A month later, senior RSS leader and SJM founder Dattopant Thengdi attacked Finance Minister Yashwant Sinha. The then SJM convener Murlidhar Rao went to the extent of saying that 'the government is not being led by political leadership but by people who are insensitive to national interests'. RSS Joint General Secretary H.V. Seshadri castigated the government for a kind of 'tandav [dance of death] of corruption'.[64] In the Vajpayee years, the RSS and the BJP were enmeshed in multiple crises: on the finance ministership of Jaswant Singh, on SJM opposition to economic reforms, and BMS criticism of the Insurance Regulation Authority Bill.[65]